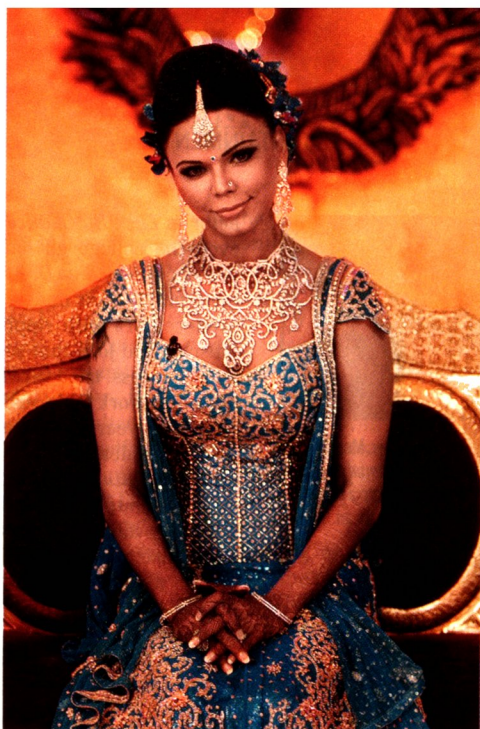




(CLOCKWISE FROM FAR LEFT)
SALMAN KHAN WAS A DESI DUDE
IN *WANTED*; RAKHI SAWANT
SIMPERED AND SHOWED OFF HER
ARRAY OF TOYBOYS; LAALI
SUFFERED FOR HER FAMILY; AAMIR
KHAN STARRED, AGAIN, IN THE
BIGGEST HIT OF THE YEAR; AMMAJI
MENACED AN ENTIRE VILLAGE;
RANBIR KAPOOR'S PREM AND SID
MADE HIM THE TWEEN KING



AS THE NEW DECADE DAWNED, IT WAS CLEAR A NEW ETHICAL UNIVERSE WAS BEING CARVED out. In a year where an 86-year-old politician was unmasked as a dirty old man and a senior police officer was revealed to be a molester, it was only fitting that Bollywood provided the moral compass.

Bollywood men came down to earth, some with their shining armour in smithereens like Shiney Ahuja. They got 38.72 per cent in BCom (Hons) and became salesmen (*Rocket Singh: Salesman of the Year*). They brought their ailing grandmothers home to old Delhi so they could pass away in peace (*Delhi-6*). And shockingly, they even advised abortion to the women they

loved instead of owning up to the responsibility (*Paa*).

As the new decade dawned, it was clear a new ethical universe was being carved out. In a year where an 86-year-old politician was unmasked as a dirty old man and a senior police officer was revealed to be an unashamed molester, perhaps it was only fitting that Bollywood provided the moral compass. Here

Radhe, a seemingly small-time thug in *Wanted*, showed he had principles. "*Main auraton aur bachchon par haath nahin uthata* (I don't strike women and children)," he said. Here again Rakhi refused to get cosy with her fiancé on *Pati, Patni Aur Woh* because she was a "Bharatiya nari". And yes, here were TV audiences reacting with visceral

anger against a 17-year-old girl's suicide 16 years ago. If television reacted to the increasing emancipation of women in society by throwing them into one traditional peril after another—from child marriage in *Balika Vadhu* to female foeticide in *Na Aana Is Des Laado*—Bollywood celebrated the honest, hard-working woman, whether it was the struggling soap